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UAE REAFFIRMS COMMITMENT TO PEACE

At G7, President stresses sovereignty, good neighbourliness, international law

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan reaffirmed the UAE's commitment to working alongside its partners to advance peace, security, stability, trust and development globally.

Addressing the 52nd G7 Summit at Evian-les-Bains, France, Sheikh Mohamed thanked French President Emmanuel Macron for hosting the summit and for the invitation to participate. He also said he was pleased to meet with friends and partners at a time of significant challenges.

Sheikh Mohamed said the region is experiencing profound upheaval and an unprecedented period of rapidly evolving challenges whose impact extends far beyond its borders.

Partners thanked

He also expressed appreciation to the G7 members and partners around the world for their support during the UAE's defence against thousands of Iranian missile and drone attacks targeting civilian sites over six consecutive weeks.

He said that the current crisis has underscored the need for greater cooperation and collective action.

He added that resilient supply chains, secure trade routes, and efficient infrastructure are essential foundations for prosperity, and that safeguarding global stability is not only a shared interest but also a collective responsibility.

In this context, the President commended the efforts of US President Donald Trump in contributing to the agreement on the memorandum of understanding between the



AFP

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan is greeted by US President Donald Trump during a working lunch as part of the G7 summit, in Evian, eastern France, yesterday.

United States and Iran. He reaffirmed that lasting and sustainable peace in the region rests on respect for the sovereignty of states, the principles of good neighbourliness, and full adherence to the rules of international law in a manner that promotes security, stability, and prosperity for all.

Potential to expand cooperation

He further highlighted the significant potential to expand cooperation in areas that will drive future progress, including the energy transition, artificial intelligence, and economic development, noting that the UAE has been a trusted and forward-looking partner in these fields.

The UAE's participation

at the G7 Summit reflects its commitment to strengthening these partnerships and investing in innovation, connectivity, and resilience as key drivers of a more prosperous future. He added that the summit would help advance cooperation in these areas in ways that support stability and promote prosperity both regionally and worldwide.

Iran remained a key topic at the summit, with leaders closely watching efforts to turn the US-Iran memorandum of understanding into a final agreement aimed at ending months of conflict in the region.

Trump firm on nuclear issue

Trump said the United States remained focused on ensuring that Iran does not acquire a nu-

clear weapon, while Tehran signalled that talks on its nuclear programme and sanctions relief could resume later this week.

Iranian state television said Iranian oil tankers and other vessels had resumed shipping following the deal, with Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister Majid Takht-Ravanchi saying the US blockade "has been lifted prior to the formal signing".

Officials say negotiations over a final agreement are expected to begin within a 60-day window after the memorandum of understanding is formally signed.

"Likely on Friday, at a location to be determined... a new round of negotiations between Iran and the United States to reach a final agreement will be-

GARGASH: NATION EMERGED STRONGER

The UAE has emerged from the latest period of regional tensions stronger, more resilient and more confident, having worked diplomatically to avert conflict while firmly safeguarding its sovereignty and national interests, Dr Anwar Gargash, Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President, said following the announcement of an understanding between the United States and Iran.

"The UAE emerges from this phase stronger, more resilient and more confident," he wrote on X. "It worked diplomatically and with credibility to avoid war, protected its sovereignty with determination and capability, and reinforced its position as a model of development, stability and prosperity in the region."

—Gulf News Report

gin," Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said.

"In the final agreement, decisions will be made on the nuclear issues and the lifting of sanctions."

Swiss signing

According to Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister, the Islamic Republic's top negotiator, Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, will attend the signing in Switzerland, which Bern said would take place at the Bürgenstock Resort overlooking Lake Lucerne.

The Swiss foreign ministry said the venue was proposed by Pakistani and Qatari mediators, as well as by the United States and Iran.

— with inputs from WAM, AFP

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Meet Zidane Iqbal of Pakistan making history at the World Cup

Former Manchester United academy player is representing Iraq

DUBAI

BY AREEBA HASHMI
Reporter

Zidane Iqbal, former Manchester United academy player, is set to become the first person of Pakistani heritage to play in the World Cup, and when he found out, he sent the news straight to his dad.

Zidane Iqbal, 23, currently plays for FC Utrecht after coming through United's youth system, where he made history as the first British South Asian player in almost 20 years to feature in the Champions League.

Now, representing Iraq at the 2026 World Cup, he is about to add another milestone to his name, one that carries enormous meaning for a country of over 240 million people whose national football team has never come close to qualifying for the tournament.

Speaking to BBC Sport, Iqbal said the realisation caught him completely off guard. "To be honest, I didn't even know it myself. I followed the account that posted it and sent it to my dad straight away. I think we were both surprised. When I tried to qualify for the World Cup with Iraq, I didn't think of anything like this."

Iqbal was born and raised in Manchester. His father is Pakistani, his mother is Iraqi,



and he carries both identities with equal pride onto every pitch he plays on. Quite literally, in fact. He wears the Iraqi flag on his left boot and the Pakistani flag on his right.

"I've grown up in Manchester my whole life so I'd say I'm a proud Mancunian, but I'm also proud of my heritage as well. I'm proud of being English, Pakistani and Iraqi," he said.

He also addressed why choosing to play for Iraq does not diminish any of that. "Me choosing to play for Iraq doesn't mean I'm not a proud Mancunian or a proud Pakistani. I just feel this is the right opportunity for me as a player, the right step in my career and an honour, but it doesn't take away the fact that I'm a Mancunian and a Pakistani as well."

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UAE distributes over Dh46 billion in VAT and excise revenues

VAT and excise collections rose 15% in 2025, says Ministry of Finance

DUBAI

BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

The UAE distributed more than Dh46 billion in Value Added Tax and Excise Tax revenues to federal and local governments by the end of 2025, marking a 15 per cent increase from the previous year, the Ministry of Finance said yesterday.

The figure compares with about Dh41 billion in 2024 and points to a steady rise in non-oil government revenues, giving federal and emirate-level authorities a broader base to fund services, infrastructure and long-term development priorities.

VAT and Excise Tax have become important contributors to public finances since their introduction, helping the UAE diversify government revenue sources

VAT and Excise Tax have become important contributors to public finances since their introduction, helping the UAE diversify government revenue sources beyond hydrocarbons.

beyond hydrocarbons. The latest numbers show how the tax system is now feeding into both federal and local budgets, with distributed revenues supporting fiscal stability while giving governments more visibility for planning.

Mohamed Bin Hadi Al Hussaini, Minister of State for Financial Affairs, said the growth in tax revenues reflects the strength of the UAE's fiscal approach and its ability to maintain stable government resources that support economic and development priorities in the years ahead.

He added that the financial

data highlights the maturity of the UAE's fiscal and tax framework, along with the transparency and discipline guiding the management of public resources.

Revenue management

The Ministry of Finance said it is working closely with federal and local entities to improve the management of public revenues and strengthen the readiness of fiscal policies to respond to economic growth and future developments. This is important because tax revenues are distributed across different levels of government, making clear revenue management essential for budgeting, planning and public-sector delivery.

Al Hussaini said the continued strengthening of this framework supports the UAE's development agenda and reinforces the competitiveness of the national economy.

The broader impact is linked to how these revenues support government spending on public services, infrastructure, economic programmes and fiscal resilience.